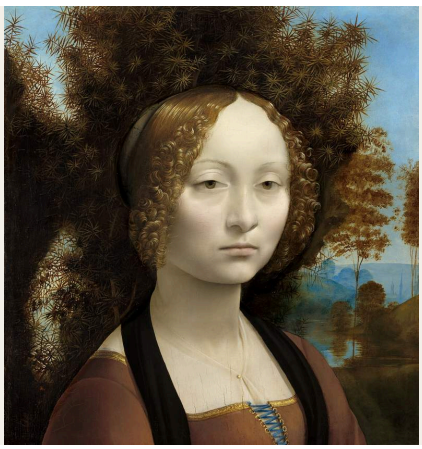
WASHINGTON, DC, UNITED STATES

National Gallery of Art: Masterpieces

Twenty works in which a pen, a clock, a boat or a flower changes the larger picture.



Vermeer's writer has paused, but the pen remains ready above the paper. David's Napoleon stands among objects arranged to suggest work continuing late into the night. These details make claims about the people represented, although a painted claim is not the same thing as independent evidence about a life.

This selection from the National Gallery of Art follows the work done by apparently subordinate objects and gestures. Some identify a subject; some organise space; others ask for belief in an image of duty, intimacy or danger. Looking closely means distinguishing those functions. A significant detail need not be a hidden symbol, and a convincing appearance need not be a candid record.

Artline selected these works from documented museum holdings. The selection is independent of the museum, and individual works may be on loan or off display. Dates and attributions retain the qualifications in the linked records.

Explore this selection in Artline

See the selected works alongside books and events from their period, or compare when the artists lived. The books and events provide context, not evidence of direct influence. Works without confirmed dates remain in this guide.

Artworks in context Who lived when?

artlines.org/guides/national-gallery-of-art

The selection · 20

1. Ginevra de' Benci
   Leonardo da Vinci · c. 1474–1478
2. A Lady Writing
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1665
3. Woman Holding a Balance
   Johannes Vermeer · c. 1664
4. The Annunciation
   Jan van Eyck · c. 1434–1436
5. Self-Portrait
   Vincent van Gogh · 1889
6. Breezing Up: A Fair Wind
   Winslow Homer · 1873-1876
7. Watson and the Shark
   John Singleton Copley · 1778
8. The Skater: William Grant
   Gilbert Stuart · 1782
9. The Voyage of Life: Childhood
   Thomas Cole · 1842
10. The Feast of the Gods
    Giovanni Bellini, with later landscape alterations by Titian · 1514; landscape reworked 1529
11. Laocoön
    El Greco · c. 1610
12. Napoleon in His Study at the Tuileries
    Jacques-Louis David · 1812
13. The Japanese Footbridge
    Claude Monet · 1899
14. Girl with a Hoop
    Pierre-Auguste Renoir · 1885
15. Self-Portrait
    Paul Gauguin · 1889
16. The Railway
    Édouard Manet · 1873
17. Giant Magnolias on a Blue Velvet Cloth
    Martin Johnson Heade · c. 1890
18. Little Girl in a Blue Armchair
    Mary Cassatt · 1878
19. The Old Violin
    John Frederick Peto · c. 1890
20. Jack-in-the-Pulpit No. IV
    Georgia O'Keeffe · 1930

01 / 20

Ginevra de' Benci

Leonardo da Vinci

c. 1474–1478 · Oil on panel · National Gallery of Art



Leonardo da Vinci, Ginevra de' Benci (obverse). National Gallery of Art, Washington, DC. Reproduction via Wikimedia Commons (PD-Art). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

Dense juniper presses close behind Ginevra, while the water and trees beyond her shoulder open a distant space. Leonardo gives the restrained face these two different settings at once. The contrast strengthens its presence without requiring an expressive gesture. Notice how a portrait can acquire depth through the relationship between its surroundings, rather than through an elaborate pose alone.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1967.6.1.a

02 / 20

A Lady Writing

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1665 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Johannes Vermeer. A Lady Writing. National Gallery of Art, Washington, 1962.10.1. NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse; compressed study reproduction. · NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse

The woman turns towards the viewer while keeping her pen poised. Vermeer makes the encounter feel like an interruption because the practical arrangement of writing remains intact. Light catches the yellow jacket against the dark wall, but it is the retained connection to the page that gives the pose its timing. Nothing establishes how long the pause will last.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1962.10.1

03 / 20

Woman Holding a Balance

Johannes Vermeer

c. 1664 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Johannes Vermeer. Woman Holding a Balance. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The small balance hangs almost weightlessly above valuables on the table. Behind the woman, the Last Judgment enlarges the question of weighing into one of moral reckoning. Vermeer brings these meanings close without turning each object into a caption for the next. The delicacy of the hand's action remains worth examining even before its possible implications are considered.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1942.9.97

04 / 20

The Annunciation

Jan van Eyck

c. 1434–1436 · Oil on canvas transferred from panel · National Gallery of Art



Jan van Eyck, The Annunciation. National Gallery of Art, Washington, DC. Reproduction via Wikimedia Commons (PD-Art). Full-frame proportional resize and JPEG compression to at most 100,000 bytes; no crop or generated content. · Public Domain Mark 1.0 / PD-Art

The angel and Mary occupy a church whose floors, inscriptions and distant architecture carry more information than the two-figure encounter alone. Van Eyck makes close reading part of devotion: small elements connect the announced event with a larger Christian history. The narrow format encourages attention to travel through the building rather than stopping at the figures' exchange.

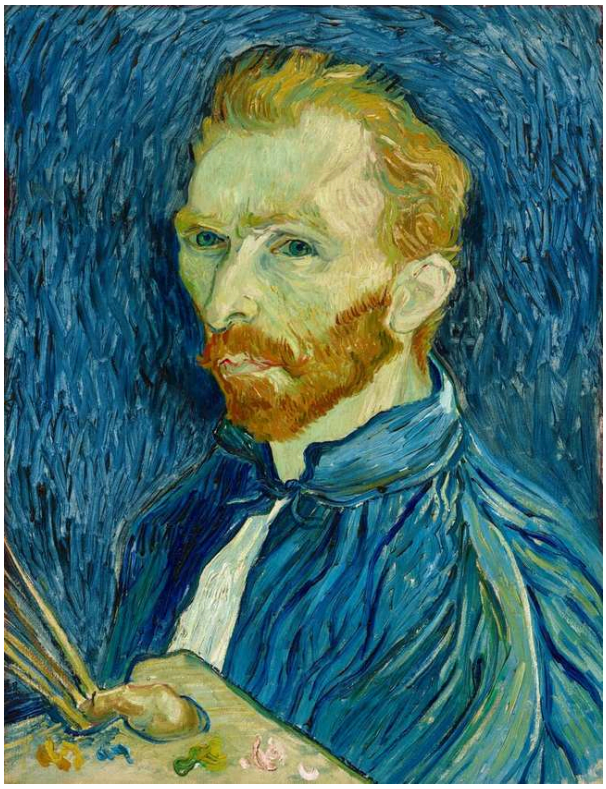
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1937.1.39

05 / 20

Self-Portrait

Vincent van Gogh

1889 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Vincent van Gogh. Self-Portrait. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The palette and brushes identify Van Gogh at work, while the strokes around and across his face show the result of that work. Tools and painted handling reinforce one another without becoming identical kinds of evidence. The face remains legible among marks that do not imitate smooth skin. A professional self-image is being constructed through both what is depicted and how it is painted.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1998.74.5

06 / 20

Breezing Up: A Fair Wind

Winslow Homer

1873-1876 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Winslow Homer. Breezing Up (A Fair Wind). National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The boat tilts, and the different positions of the man and boys show them accommodating its movement. Homer gives the apparent pleasure of sailing a practical basis in balance and attention. The choppy water keeps the vessel from becoming a static platform for a group portrait. Their occupation of the boat is inseparable from what the wind is doing to it.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1943.13.1

07 / 20

Watson and the Shark

John Singleton Copley

1778 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



John Singleton Copley. Watson and the Shark. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The rescue depends on several actions meeting at the right time: reaching towards the swimmer, positioning the boat and confronting the shark. Copley coordinates those efforts through the men's bodies. The distant waterfront locates the episode but offers no immediate help. Attention remains at the point where a set of separate gestures must become a successful collective act.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.6.1

08 / 20

The Skater: William Grant

Gilbert Stuart

1782 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Gilbert Stuart. The Skater (Portrait of William Grant). National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

Grant's crossed arms give the upper body composure, while the angled leg reveals the balance needed below. Stuart adapts the full-length portrait to a skill performed in motion. The distant skaters establish the shared activity without rivaling the principal sitter. The figure's dignity depends on controlled movement, not on the immobility of someone standing for inspection.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1950.18.1

09 / 20

The Voyage of Life: Childhood

Thomas Cole

1842 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Thomas Cole. The Voyage of Life: Childhood. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The child rides rather than directs the golden boat. Cole turns the river into a route through an allegorical life, with the angel accompanying its beginning. The dark opening behind and the lush, bright world ahead give direction a temporal meaning. A landscape feature does narrative work here: travel across water becomes a way to represent the passage of years.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1971.16.1

10 / 20

The Feast of the Gods

Giovanni Bellini, with later landscape alterations by Titian

1514; landscape reworked 1529 · National Gallery of Art



Giovanni Bellini. The Feast of the Gods. Image: WikiArt. Public domain (WikiArt label). Proportionally resized and JPEG compressed; no crop. · Public domain (WikiArt label)

Food, vessels and loosely gathered bodies make the gods' company resemble an outdoor meal. The landscape has its own history of revision: Bellini painted the work in 1514, and Titian reworked its setting in 1529. The apparent unity is therefore the product of more than one moment and one hand, a useful caution against imagining every finished surface as a single decision.

Object source · Open artwork

11 / 20

Laocoön

El Greco

c. 1610 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



El Greco. Laocoon. WikiArt source label: Public domain. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/el-greco/laocoon · Public domain (WikiArt source label)

The struggling bodies pull in several directions against the serpents. El Greco places the ancient subject before a city resembling Toledo, refusing the comfortable distance of a conventionally classical setting. Turbulent clouds continue the instability of the limbs above the figures. The threatened balance is not confined to the episode; it becomes a property of the entire painted environment.

Object source · Open artwork

12 / 20

Napoleon in His Study at the Tuileries

Jacques-Louis David

1812 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Jacques-Louis David. The Emperor Napoleon in His Study at the Tuileries. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

Papers, clock and candle are recruited to portray a ruler absorbed in administrative duty. Even the slight disorder of Napoleon's uniform belongs to that carefully constructed account. David does not offer an accidental glimpse into the study. The objects are evidence within the portrait's argument about diligence, not independent proof that the depicted moment happened exactly as shown.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1961.9.15

13 / 20

The Japanese Footbridge

Claude Monet

1899 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Claude Monet. The Japanese Footbridge. National Gallery of Art, Washington, 1992.9.1. NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse; compressed study reproduction. · NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse

The bridge crosses the upper pond without opening a route to a distant horizon. Monet keeps attention inside the garden, where lily pads, reflected growth and vegetation repeatedly overlap. Depth remains available, but the strokes continually return the eye to the surface. The bridge helps organise that uncertainty by giving the dense field one clearly spanning shape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1992.9.1

14 / 20

Girl with a Hoop

Pierre-Auguste Renoir

1885 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Pierre-Auguste Renoir. Girl with a Hoop. National Gallery of Art, Washington, 1963.10.58. NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse; compressed study reproduction. · NGA Open Access — unrestricted reuse

The hoop connects the girl's hand to the ground and gives her standing pose a possible activity. Renoir does not need to show a game in progress. Broken garden light surrounds a figure who remains sufficiently still to be portrayed. The toy negotiates the difference: she can appear as a particular child outdoors without the image becoming a complete anecdote.

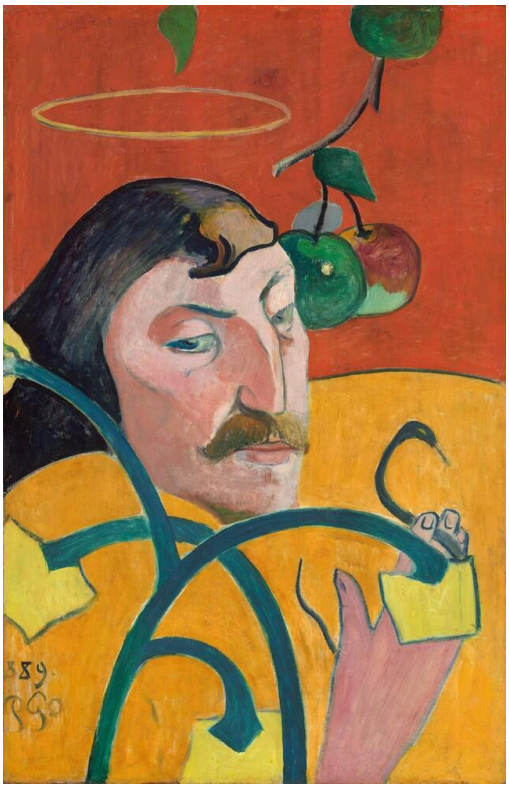
Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.58

15 / 20

Self-Portrait

Paul Gauguin

1889 · Oil on wood · National Gallery of Art



Paul Gauguin. Self-Portrait. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The halo, snake and apples make competing religious associations cluster around Gauguin's head. Red and yellow fields deny the self-image an ordinary room in which to settle. These signs are acts of self-fashioning rather than straightforward confessions. The painting reveals how the artist chooses to complicate his public image, not an unmediated account of his moral character.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1963.10.150

16 / 20

The Railway

Édouard Manet

1873 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Édouard Manet. The Railway. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The woman looks out while the child turns towards the railings and steam. Manet divides attention between an encounter offered to the viewer and an activity withheld beyond the bars. The book and dog keep the seated figure occupied in a quieter register. The railway matters through its interruption of visibility; a clearly presented locomotive is unnecessary to the scene.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1956.10.1

17 / 20

Giant Magnolias on a Blue Velvet Cloth

Martin Johnson Heade

c. 1890 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Martin Johnson Heade. Giant Magnolias on a Blue Velvet Cloth. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The magnolias lie on heavy fabric rather than growing in a garden. Heade makes their white petals substantial through the contrast with the deep blue folds. Leaves and dark stems help separate the blossoms while keeping the arrangement close. The change of setting allows flowers to be considered as objects with weight and surfaces, beyond their role in a landscape.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1996.14.1

18 / 20

Little Girl in a Blue Armchair

Mary Cassatt

1878 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Mary Cassatt. Little Girl in a Blue Armchair. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

The child sprawls across furniture large enough to make her temporary occupation of it unmistakable. Cassatt does not correct the body's ungainly ease into a formal portrait pose. Patterned blue upholstery fills much of the room, competing with the small sitter. That imbalance gives childhood a physical measure: adult surroundings continue to exceed the body resting among them.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1983.1.18

19 / 20

The Old Violin

John Frederick Peto

c. 1890 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



John Frederick Peto. The Old Violin. National Gallery of Art. NGA Open Access — public domain. Compressed full-frame reproduction. · NGA Open Access — public domain

Peto paints wear as carefully as he paints the violin's apparent thickness. Tattered music, marked wood and shadows help flat pigment impersonate separate objects on a door. The deception depends on ordinary evidence of use, not immaculate surfaces. A viewer can know perfectly well that this is a painting and still examine the details that make it look otherwise.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1974.19.1

20 / 20

Jack-in-the-Pulpit No. IV

Georgia O'Keeffe

1930 · Oil on canvas · National Gallery of Art



Georgia O'Keeffe. Jack-in-the-Pulpit No. IV. WikiArt source label: Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use. Proportional resize and JPEG compression; no crop. Source: https://www.wikiart.org/en/georgia-o-keeffe/jack-in-the-pulpit-no-iv · Georgia O'Keeffe Fair Use (WikiArt source label)

O'Keeffe enlarges the flower until dark folds and a narrow pale form nearly fill the available space. Curving bands lead towards the central opening, giving botanical structure a scale at which it approaches abstraction. The plant need not disappear for those shapes to acquire independence. Recognition and close attention to colour can remain active together.

Object source · Open artwork · Inventory: 1987.58.3

Ask what the detail actually establishes

A pen can establish an activity; a clock can help construct an image of diligence. Neither automatically reveals a private state of mind. Carry that distinction into comparisons between these works. The selection is not a current gallery itinerary; consult museum records for attribution updates, display status and practical visiting information.

Further reading

A Treatise on Painting

Leonardo da Vinci; translated by John Francis Rigaud · Read free · English

Leonardo’s notes examine faces, gestures, light and landscape. They give a closer view of the problems behind the first portrait and offer questions to bring to later artists who solved similar problems differently.

Museum website · Official collection guide

Sources and visitor information checked: 2026-10-12